field. For me, school was just about sport. That was it. During our 40-minute break I'd be playing sport; if we had 'civics' from 1.30 to 3.30 p.m. (cadets, or music … all that nonsense), I'd get out of it and play football or touch rugby. Afterwards I'd return to class with my uniform soaked in sweat.

I couldn't sit in a classroom and apply my mind for 20 minutes, let alone for those double sessions of one hour. The only time I enjoyed a lesson was when they showed us a video, which meant that I could have a quiet doss in the back of the classroom. All I ever thought about were the weekend games that lay ahead. Basically, I was just like any other sports-mad South African schoolboy.

On the sports field, it was a different story. My cricket was going great guns and, at the age of 15, I was selected for the under-19 Western Province XI to play in the Nuffield Week. Although I was scoring plenty of runs, cricket wasn't a doddle all the time. I remember the first time I was pinned by a genuine quickie.

His name was Brett Chambers, and he attended Fish Hoek High School. I was 15 and never used to wear a helmet … that was, until I faced Brett. The ball was flying past me – it was a real eye-opener. I'd never before faced pace of this calibre, and I didn't like it at all. I thought, shit, if this oke bounces me and hits me on the head, he'll clean my pipes …

He did hit me. I was trying to get out of the way of one of Brett's lightning bolts when the ball hit me flush on the chest. It stopped me dead in my tracks. I was like, later for this, I'm out of here. I nicked off and walked back to the changing room. It was one of the few times I was happy to get out. Fortunately Brett came to Bishops shortly afterwards, so he became a teammate. He was a great guy, and easily the quickest bowler in school cricket in the country at that stage.

I'm not sure what happened to him. He played Nuffield for Province, but I don't think he made SA Schools. Funny, but nowadays I still think about those moments. When I prepare myself for an innings, I make use of pre-game visualisation, and those moments, when you've really been shaken up by a bowler, stick with you. It doesn't matter whether it's Shoaib Akhtar now, or Brett Chambers 20-odd years ago.

That was school cricket, but I was also making a name for myself in senior cricket by this time as well. By Standard 8, as a 16-year-old, I was